

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



After dropping off bins of books, Reaching Across Illinois Library System sorter and driver Chris Lysne departs the Naperville Public Library on April 17 with materials to be sorted and delivered to other locations. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Libraries' book sharing threatened by federal cuts

Delivery system gives patrons access to titles their local branches don't have, but Trump has gutted source of funds

By **Molly Morrow and Tess Kenny**
Aurora Beacon-News

Peggy Frank loves old research books, especially ones about history. But they aren't always available through her local library collection in Naperville, where she's lived for the past 45 years.

But in Frank's community — and hundreds like it in Illinois — proximity is not a prerequisite for access. Not with a state's-worth of reading material available for the asking.

For nearly 15 years, she has made use of a popular library loaning system that has allowed suburban towns, local universi-

ties and small museums to share their books and other materials with each other. Overseen by the Reaching Across Illinois Library System and partially funded by the federal government, the books are shuttled between libraries and loaned out to interested parties in just a few days.

The delivery program has become so entrenched in northern and western Illinois communities, more than 7.9 million books and other resources were shared among 1,250 libraries last year at no extra cost to the institutions or patrons. Couriers also logged more than 1.1 million miles moving the materials around the area, according to RAILS.



■ Museums across Illinois learn their federal grants have been eliminated, **Page 8**

"It's like magic," Frank, 72, said.

But that magic may soon disappear.

President Donald Trump last month ordered the gutting of the Institute of Museum and Library Services, a federal agency that serves as a key source of funding for museums, libraries and

educational institutions across the country. The cuts, which are still being rolled out, could prove devastating to the interlibrary loan program throughout the region.

RAILS and the Illinois Heartland Library System, the state's other major library delivery service that reaches southern and central parts of Illinois, receive about \$2.5 million annually for delivery services, about one-third of their budgets, through IMLS funding. Though the state was told to expect this year's award around April 20, the program officer who oversees Illinois funding has been terminated and the money has not yet arrived, according to a spokesman for Illinois Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias.

Several states, including California, Connecticut and

Turn to Libraries, Page 2

'What a year': A WGN reporter's public battle

Diagnosed with colorectal cancer at 44, Mike Lowe shared his experience. Now, he's at a turning point

By **Lisa Schencker**
Chicago Tribune

Almost exactly a year after he was diagnosed with colorectal cancer, WGN-TV reporter Mike Lowe's cellphone pinged as he drove to work early last week.

It was a message from his doctor — the results of his latest colonoscopy, a test meant to show whether six weeks of radiation and four months of chemotherapy had worked. The results were exactly what he had hoped to see: The cancer was no longer detectable.

"Getting those results, it was just the most amazing feeling," Lowe said. "I think back to one year ago, when I went to the initial doctor's appointment ... In some ways it feels like forever and in some ways it feels like the blink of an eye — but what a year."

It was a year that started with surprise at his diagnosis at the age of 44. Lowe's surprise, however, quickly turned into a conviction that he would use his platform as a television news reporter to raise awareness about the disease, which has increasingly been striking people at younger



Nurses Mary Joos, left, and Mike Marasigan get Mike Lowe settled into his recovery room after a colonoscopy at Northwestern Lake Forest Hospital on April 18. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ages. For the past year, he's taken WGN viewers along on his journey, talking about his diagnosis in news segments, inviting cameras into his appointments and procedures and sharing very personal details about his experience.

"It is a public health crisis in this country where younger and younger people are being diag-

nosed with colorectal cancer," Lowe said.

About 20% of colorectal cases were in people ages 54 or younger in 2019 — almost double the percentage as in 1995, according to the American Cancer Society. Scientists aren't sure exactly what's causing the increase in diagnoses among younger

patients, but they're urging people to see their doctors if they experience unusual symptoms such as abdominal pain, changes in bowel habits, diarrhea, bloody stools or constipation.

Colorectal cancer is the fourth-most common type of cancer in

Turn to Diagnosis, Page 4

STATE GOVERNMENT

Ethics reforms slow in coming

Pritzker, lawmakers moving sluggishly despite uptick in criminal convictions

By **Ray Long, Dan Petrella and Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

In the six years since Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker took office, members of the Illinois General Assembly have run afoul of the law at a staggering pace, even for a body with a history of greed and graft stretching back more than a century.

During Pritzker's reign in Springfield, 11 now-former lawmakers have pleaded guilty or been convicted at trial of crimes, a stain on the Illinois government he heads even though the governor himself has not been accused of any wrongdoing. That total avoided becoming an even dozen when a mistrial was declared last week in the federal court case alleging Democratic state Sen. Emil Jones III of Chicago sought a bribe and a job for an intern from a rogue red-light camera company executive working as a government mole.

The rapid rate of such convictions, at least in the short term, surpasses even the notorious Chicago City Council, which has seen nearly 40 members imprisoned in the last half century. And no conviction in recent memory was bigger than the epic February takedown of Chicago Democratic powerhouse and former Illinois House Speaker Michael Madigan, the longest-serving speaker in American history.

The blemishes on state government come as the Tribune in 2024 published its series "Culture of Corruption," which outlined how state laws are riddled with loopholes and plagued by weak oversight, issues underscored earlier this month when the Tribune revealed Illinois election officials said Senate President Don Harmon collected millions of dollars more in campaign donations than he was allowed to under a law Harmon sponsored. Harmon, an Oak Park Democrat, is appealing the decision.

Despite all of that, as the legislature enters the final weeks of its spring session, strengthening the state's ethical safeguards doesn't appear to be anywhere near the top of the agenda in Springfield. Pritzker, Harmon and their fellow Democratic leader, House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch of Hillside, have done little this year to press for higher standards, and numerous proposals — from Democrats and Republicans alike — to address lobbying, conflicts of interest and other ethics-related issues have languished.

Turn to Ethics, Page 3

INSIDE

Israel renews airstrikes near Beirut

Israeli jets struck Beirut's southern suburbs Sunday after issuing a warning, marking the third Israeli strike on the area since a ceasefire took effect in late November.

Nation & World, Page 2

A raucous night with rapper Denzel Curry

It was a rap show, but also something more frenetic and wild, as Curry took his young audience at Chicago's Salt Shed on a journey that was both musical and physical.

Arts & Living

